work on the pipeline; the reaction of some of our allies suggested that money spoke louder to them than principle. They said they wanted freedom for the Polish people but also wanted to expand trade with the Eastern bloc, and they refused to join our efforts to block work on the new pipeline that was to bring natural gas from Siberia to Western Europe.

As I thought back on that letter I'd sent to Brezhnev after the shooting, I realized I hadn't made much progress with the Russians in reducing Cold War tensions during my first year in office. Although Brezhnev's Christmas message had made it clear that they knew there was a new team in Washington, the Soviets were acting more like international brigands than ever.

Unfortunately, as my first year came to an end, it also appeared we weren't making much progress in curing our economic problems. Like a runaway train that keeps hurtling along the tracks long after its locomotive has lost power, the economy was racing deeper into a recession that was the product of years of mismanagement in Washington, and was depriving millions of Americans of their livelihood. Although the prime interest rate was no longer 21.5 percent as it was in January, it was 15 percent, still too high for an economy badly in need of a jump start. The country had added more than 250,000 new jobs during the year, but the national unemployment rate was 8.4 percent, the highest in six years, and still climbing. In industrial states like Michigan and Pennsylvania, the rate was even higher, and hundreds of factories were being forced to close their gates. New home sales and new car sales were in a tailspin. In all, more than nine million Americans were out of work.

Tip O'Neill used every opportunity he got to lambaste me as a "rich man's president" who cared nothing about the little man, the unemployed, or the poor, and said my economic program was a "cruel hoax." The press wrote that